

U.S. STRIKES IRAN

KHAMENEI IS DEAD, TRUMP AND NETANYAHU SAY



Waves of explosions hit Tehran on Saturday. Israel's military said it had, in part, targeted a gathering of senior Iranian officials.

Attack, With Aid From Israel,
Risks a Broader Conflict

This article is by **Aaron Boxerman**, **Tyler Pager**, **Farnaz Fassihi** and **Ronen Bergman**.

The United States and Israel attacked Iran on Saturday in a major assault that threatened a broader regional conflict, and President Trump announced that Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the nation's supreme leader for almost 37 years and an implacable enemy of the two countries, had been killed in the attacks.

"Khamenei, one of the most evil people in History, is dead," Mr. Trump wrote on Truth Social. There was no immediate confirmation from the Iranian government.

Earlier in the day, Iranian officials had dismissed such claims as bravado or psychological warfare. Later, the ayatollah's official account on X posted an image rich with Shia religious symbolism, of a faceless clerical figure holding a flaming sword.

In a televised address earlier on Saturday, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel had destroyed the "compound of the tyrant Khamenei" in a surprise attack that morning. "There are many indications that this tyrant is gone," he said.

Israel's military said it had targeted a gathering of senior Iranian officials in the opening strikes. It later said that several of Iran's most senior military leaders had been killed, including Gen. Mohammad Pakpour, the chief of the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps, the most powerful force in Iran; the defense minister, Gen. Aziz Nasrizadeh; and Ali Shamkhani, former head of the Iranian Navy and a close adviser to Ayatollah Khamenei.

It was not immediately clear which country's forces had killed Ayatollah Khamenei, but either way, the action exhibited a high degree of coordination between the United States and Israel. Satellite imagery showed a plume of smoke and extensive damage at the supreme leader's high-security compound.

Mr. Trump and Mr. Netanyahu made clear that regime change was a goal of the vast waves of strikes on Iran. But it is uncertain whether removing Ayatollah Khamenei, 86, would result in significant changes to the system he led, as many people in authority owed their positions to him.

The power to choose a new supreme leader rests with the Assembly of Experts, a conservative body of clerics who, given Ayatollah Khamenei's age and infirmities, have probably given ample thought to potential successors.

In retaliation for the U.S.-led attack, Iran fired waves of ballistic missiles at Israel, where the authorities reported one death, while the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Bahrain and Kuwait — all of which host U.S. military bases —



OFFICE OF IRAN'S SUPREME LEADER, VIA A.P.

Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the supreme leader of Iran for almost 37 years, in January.

Trump's War of Choice, With a Key Question: Why Now?

By **DAVID E. SANGER**

WASHINGTON — With his broad attack on Iran early Saturday morning and his call to the Iranian people to overthrow their government, President Trump has embarked on the ultimate war of choice.

He was not driven by an immediate threat. There was no race for a bomb. Iran is further from the capability to build a nuclear weapon today than it has been in several years, thanks largely to the success of the president's previous strike on Iranian nuclear enrichment sites, in June.

While Mr. Trump claimed Tehran was ultimately aiming to reach to the United States with its array of missiles, even his own Defense Intelligence Agency concluded last year that it would be a decade before Iran could get past the technological and production hurdles to produce a significant arsenal.

And there were no indications of a coming Iranian attack on the United States, its allies or its bases in the region. Instead, Mr. Trump struck the Islamic Republic largely because he apparently sensed a remarkable moment of weakness for the government — and an opportunity for the United States to topple Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and the Islamic

Citing Grievances Like
1970s Crisis, Not an
Imminent Threat

Revolutionary Guards Corps after 47 years of episodic confrontations, which he described at length in an eight-minute video. Late Saturday afternoon, Mr. Trump announced on social media that Ayatollah Khamenei had been killed in the attack.

But unlike past presidents putting American forces at risk — and, in an age of terrorism and cyberattacks, perhaps civilians

as well — Mr. Trump did not spend months building a case for war. He never presented evidence of an imminent threat, or answered the question of why a nuclear program he claimed he had "obliterated" eight months ago was now on the brink of revival.

His pretaped video, released in the middle of the night as the missiles started exploding in Tehran, recited a list of long-running grievances with Iran, including its brutal use of terror. But he never explained why in the pantheon of threats facing the United States, including an already-nuclear-armed North

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A satellite image shows damage at the compound of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader.

MORE ON THE STRIKES

RETALIATION Iranian missile attacks targeted U.S. military facilities in the Middle East and hit Israel and several countries in the Persian Gulf. **PAGE 11**

IN ISRAEL Across the country, streets emptied and people raced toward bomb shelters as sirens warned of a wave of missile launches from Iran. **PAGE 12**

IN WASHINGTON Following the attack, Democrats and a few Republicans escalated calls for swift votes on whether to curb the president's war powers. **PAGE 12**

IN IRAN Some Iranians said they felt that they were left to fend for themselves by their government, which provided little guidance even as the bombs fell. **PAGE 12**



Why Epstein Inquiries Yielded So Few Charges

This article is by **Benjamin Weiser**, **Matthew Goldstein** and **Mike Baker**.

It was early evening on Saturday, July 6, 2019, when Jeffrey Epstein disembarked from a private plane for the final time. Federal agents were waiting at Teterboro Airport in New Jersey to arrest him.

"Is this about sex trafficking?" Mr. Epstein asked as he was being driven to the F.B.I.'s offices in Lower Manhattan, according to notes taken by an agent. "Is this

Missed Opportunities, and Limited Focus of Prosecutors

about underage?"

Nobody replied, but the answer was yes. Later, as he was being booked into jail, Mr. Epstein remarked: "Oh, this is bad. This is really bad."

That was certainly true for Mr. Epstein, who would die in a jail cell

five weeks later. But for the vast majority of the men and women who had either enabled Mr. Epstein or may have committed sexual assault, it turned out that there was little to fear.

Aside from Mr. Epstein's long-time conspirator Ghislaine Maxwell, none of his friends or associates have been criminally charged in the United States. In the six-plus years since his death, the lack of prosecutions has given rise to outrage and conspiracy theories about why powerful people have

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Trump Sows Fears About Election Interference

By **SHANE GOLDMACHER** and **NICK CORASANITI**

Ahead of the midterm elections, an emboldened President Trump has shown an increased eagerness to leverage the full investigative, prosecutorial and legislative powers of the federal government to bend election mechanics to his will.

With his words and deeds, the president — who pushed to overturn his 2020 defeat but declared his 2024 victory legitimate — appears to be undermining Americans' trust that the midterms will be free and fair.

As the political environment darkens for his party, Mr. Trump is again warning Republicans that Democrats are going to rig the results. At the same time, he is taking actions that make Democrats

G.O.P. Could 'Subvert' the Midterm Vote, Democrats Warn

fear that Republicans are actually going to subvert the election.

Mr. Trump has shown himself unbound by precedent in his second term, and with prominent election deniers in powerful federal posts and top cabinet officials on the hunt for evidence of voter fraud, his moves have heightened anxieties about potential interference.

He has called for Republicans to "nationalize" elections, though the Constitution leaves their administration to the states. The

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